

Fasting before your surgery

Fasting means not eating or drinking for a set time before your anaesthetic. It matters for your safety. It lowers the risk of stomach contents entering your lungs while you are under anaesthesia.

1 Before surgery

Your hospital will give you exact fasting times. Always follow those. Times can differ depending on your operation, your health, and the time of your surgery. The information below is a general guide only. If your hospital's instructions differ from this page, follow the hospital.

Taking a GLP-1 medicine such as Ozempic, Wegovy or Mounjaro? Your fasting is different from the standard advice on this page. Please follow the GLP-1 medications before surgery guidance instead.

A general guide for adults

6 hours before	Stop eating solid food , and stop milk or drinks that contain milk (such as a coffee with milk). A light meal is fine up to this point unless told otherwise.
2 hours before	Stop clear fluids. Up until 2 hours before, you may have small amounts of clear fluids: water, clear cordial, pulp-free apple juice, or black tea or coffee (no milk).
On waking, before you leave	If your hospital allows, a few sips of water to take essential medicines is usually fine. Check this with them first.

What counts as a clear fluid?

A clear fluid is one you can see through. **Yes:** water, clear cordial, black tea or coffee (no milk), pulp-free clear apple juice. **No:** milk, milky tea or coffee, smoothies, juice with pulp, alcohol.

Under modern fasting guidelines, many clear carbonated soft drinks (for example clear lemonade) are counted as clear fluids. However, some hospitals still ask you to avoid fizzy drinks before surgery. If your hospital's instructions differ from this, follow your hospital.

Your usual medicines

Keep taking your regular medicines as normal unless you have been told otherwise. Some medicines (for example certain diabetes or blood-thinning medicines) may need to be adjusted before surgery. If you are unsure, ask the hospital, your surgeon, or your GP. Do not stop important medicines without advice.

Other things to avoid

- No chewing gum or lollies inside the fasting window. They count as eating.
- No smoking or vaping on the day before surgery if you can avoid it.
- Do not drink alcohol the night before or the day of surgery.

If you accidentally eat or drink inside your fasting window, do not just turn up. Tell the hospital as soon as you can. Your surgery may need to be delayed for your safety.